



## Tax official declared not guilty in DUI trial

Judge says prosecutors failed to prove Steele was under influence

By A.D. Quig  
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A judge declared Cook County Board of Review Commissioner Samantha Steele not guilty of driving under the influence late Tuesday morning.

While Cook County prosecutors established a “suspicion” of impairment, Judge Donald Suriano said they failed to definitively prove Steele was under the influence of alcohol when she crashed a friend’s car into two parked vehicles along Ashland Avenue in November 2024.

Steele refused a field sobriety test and a blood draw that night, and did not show “obvious signs of impairment,” Suriano said, noting the bottle of wine in her front passenger seat was corked and sealed within a bag. “The burden has not been met,” he concluded, declaring her not guilty.

Prosecutors had argued she exhibited slurred speech, could not keep her head up, swayed while standing and smelled of alcohol. She was also “extraordinarily disrespectful” to the officers that responded to the crash, a sign of impaired judgment.

See TRIAL on Page A5

## Zelenskyy slams Russia’s ‘cynicism’

Deadly airstrikes hit Ukraine hours before ceasefire takes effect

By Hanna Arhirova  
ASSOCIATED PRESS

KYIV, Ukraine — Russian drone and missile strikes carried out overnight and later Tuesday killed at least 22 people and wounded more than 80 others, Ukrainian authorities said, hours before Kyiv was due to enact a ceasefire and three days before Moscow promised its own pause in hostilities.

On Tuesday afternoon, Russian glide bombs smashed into the eastern city of Kramatorsk, the southern city of Zaporizhzhia and the northern city of Chernihiv, killing at least 17 civilians and wounding 45 others, officials said.

Attacks the previous night killed five people and wounded 39, according to authorities.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy rebuked Moscow for what he said was its “utter cynicism” in launching the attacks after Russia announced a unilateral ceasefire over two days later this week while it marks the 81st anniversary of defeating Nazi Germany in World War II.

See UKRAINE on Page A9

# Dismissed judge sues US



Former immigration judge Carla Espinoza has filed a lawsuit against the federal government following her dismissal from the post last July. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Ex-immigration jurist says she was fired based on work as lawyer for immigrants and race, sex

By Caroline Kubzansky  
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A former Chicago immigration judge has accused the federal government of firing her based on her previous work as a lawyer for immigrants as well as her race and sex.

In a lawsuit filed Tuesday in U.S. District Court in Chicago, attorneys for former Judge Carla Espinoza argued that the Trump administration’s Justice Department violated Espinoza’s First Amendment rights and federal equal rights protections when

they terminated her as an immigration judge last July.

She was one of nine judges to leave the Chicago immigration court in a wave of departures, firings and buyouts in the first year of the second Trump administration. All told, the court lost nearly half the judges who were on the bench in January 2025. The turbulence at the city’s immigration court mirrored a nationwide exodus of judges amid a rapidly changing landscape for immigrants, attorneys and advocates.

See JUDGE on Page A2



## ‘WE’RE VERY PROUD’

As the first year of Chicago native Pope Leo XIV’s pontificate comes to a close, the longtime missionary has championed migrants, uplifted his hometown — and challenged Trump

**Above:** Pope Leo XIV, center bottom, leaves after an audience with Catholic religion teachers in the Paul VI Hall at the Vatican on April 25. **ALESSANDRA TARANTINO/AP**

By Angie Leventis Lourgos  
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

It was a class reunion like no other.

Ten 1969 graduates of St. Mary of the Assumption school on the city’s Far South Side traveled to Vatican City to reconnect with a fellow alum whom they now call Holy Father.

Pope Leo XIV, once a choir boy and top student at the now-defunct church, embraced his grammar schoolmates from more than a half-century ago at St. Peter’s Square in mid-March.

“I was a nervous wreck,” recalled Sherry Stone, a St. Mary’s graduate who grew up with the pope. “The whole experience was just amazing.”

Nearly a year ago, Stone wept with joy at the news that her old friend Robert Francis Prevost — born in Chicago and raised in south suburban Dolton — made history as the first American to be elected pope.

Like many prognosticators, she never thought a cardinal who hailed from the United States would ascend to lead some 1.4 billion Catholics worldwide, defying all conventional geopolitical wisdom at the time.

Yet after the white smoke streamed from the Sistine Chapel chimney and Prevost’s name was announced from the balcony of St. Peter’s Basilica on May 8, 2025, Stone — along with so many others from the Chicago area — exulted in the improbable elevation of their new home-grown pontiff.

“It’s a great thing for Chicago. It’s a great thing for the

See POPE on Page A4

### SPORTS

#### Bears are looking ahead

Ten areas to watch for as the NFC North champion Bears prepare for rookie minicamp and to solidify their position in the division.

### ARTS & LIVING

#### Evanston’s Kraus wins Pulitzer

Daniel Kraus, the prolific novelist known for his many horror novels, won the 2026 Pulitzer Prize for fiction for his World War I novel “Angel Down.” **Page B8**

### FOOD & HEALTH

#### A sense of nostalgia

Kumiko, the award-winning Japanese eating bar in the West Loop, reclaims its culture with comfort and conviction under chef Julia Momosé.

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### WEATHER FORECAST

**TODAY** H: 58 L: 39  
**THU.** H: 60 L: 47  
**FRI.** H: 63 L: 46  
Complete details on Page A16

### INDEX

Almanac ..... A9  
Arts & Living ..... B8  
Comics ..... B12-B13  
Crossword ..... B13  
Editorials ..... A6  
Horoscope ..... B12  
Nation & World ..... B4  
Obituaries ..... A9  
Television ..... B11

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